

cal treatment abroad by paying an additional premium.

This feature is particularly valuable for critical illnesses such as cancer, advanced neurological disorders, or organ transplants, where treatment abroad might offer better outcomes or shorter wait times. It also appeals to non-resident Indians (NRIs), high-net-worth individuals (HNIs), and frequent travellers who want to ensure that their insurance isn't geographically limited.

However, coverage terms vary. Some plans offer worldwide coverage, excluding or including the US and Canada, depending on the chosen rider. Others have tiered pricing, where adding the US/Canada—due to higher healthcare costs—raises the premium more than other countries.

Global coverage riders are typically offered on high-value policies with sum insured ranging from ₹1 crore to ₹6 crore, giving customers ample financial buffer for international treatments.

BASIC VS COMPREHENSIVE

For young, healthy individuals, a simple hospitalisation policy might still be adequate. But as health risks grow, it becomes more prudent to upgrade to a comprehensive plan with relevant riders.

Rakesh Kaul, the Chief Business Officer of SBI General Insurance, believes that new-age lifestyle disorders and rising medical inflation are leading to increased healthcare costs. He says a modern cover ensures extended protection at an affordable premium and provides a safety net for your savings.

“New-age health insurance policies such as Elevate offering features like 30-day waiting period for select pre-existing conditions,



“New-age insurance policies are generally more expensive because they offer broader coverage and additional features”

PRIYA DESHMUKH

HEAD HEALTH PRODUCTS, OPERATIONS & SERVICES, ICICI LOMBARD



“Cumulative bonuses in most policies allow unlimited coverage growth, often without paying extra, making them ideal for handling medical inflation”

AMIT CHHABRA

CHIEF BUSINESS OFFICER—GENERAL INSURANCE, POLICYBAZAAR

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one-time infinite claim amount, unlimited cumulative bonus, and more have competitive premium in comparison to products offering similar features. Such policies offer a customisable feature bouquet with a simple base coverage allowing customers flexibility to modify premiums,” says Priya Deshmukh—Head Health Products, Operations & Services, ICICI Lombard.

This brings us to a critical question: Are new-age policies more expensive? The answer is yes. Premium for a rider can be 10–25% higher than a basic policy, depending on the rider selected.

With customisation, customers can control what they want to pay for. “If you pick everything—unlimited sum insured, day-one cover, OPD, wellness benefits—your premium will naturally be higher. But most policies let you add features as you go. You only pay for what you need,” explains Chhabra.

The message is clear. Health insurance is no longer just about protecting against hospital bills. It's also about managing long-term health risks and protecting yourself across different stages of life. **BT**

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